

PFL-AI Body of Knowledge

The reference for the PCI AI Project Finance Leader
Project economics · structuring · financial mathematics · the
governed use of AI

FIRST EDITION — PHASE 1 PROTOTYPE (NOT FOR RELEASE)

PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL

Finance intelligently. Control predictively. Deliver successfully.

AI proposes; the professional verifies, decides and remains accountable.

— Prototype notice

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01

PART ONE

Foundations

Domains 1–4 — the profession, accounting foundations, financial mathematics and investment appraisal: the financial grammar of project finance leadership.



03

DOMAIN 3

Time Value of Money and Financial Mathematics (quantitative flagship)

Group: Foundations (Domain 3 of 4 in Part One). **Target:** ~72 pages. **Binds to:** the PCI Book Pattern Specification and the shared registries ([docs/books/registries/](#)). This domain is the definitive home of the discounting symbols — $PV(x)$, $FV(x)$, $DF(t)$, r , n , i_{nom} , i_{real} , π , annuity payment A — every later domain restates them from here. Because this book is discounting-heavy, PV written bare is reserved for Earned Value contexts only; present value is always written $PV(x)$ or in words. British English; USD (+SAR where useful, indicative $USD\ 1 \approx SAR\ 3.75$).

— Why this domain exists

Every judgment a project finance leader makes — whether an investment is worth making (Domain 4), how much debt a project can carry (Domain 10), what a concession's payment stream is worth (Domain 7), whether a delay destroys value (Domain 8) — reduces at some point to one question: what is money at one date worth at another date? Time value of money (TVM) is the machinery that answers it. This domain builds that machinery from first principles: interest and growth (KA 3.1), the annuity family and loan schedules that debt structures are made of (KA 3.2), and the adjustments — inflation, escalation and currency — that separate a defensible model from a spreadsheet accident (KA 3.3). Nothing in this domain is optional equipment: the financial models of Domain 6 are, in the end, disciplined arrangements of exactly these calculations, and the coverage ratios lenders live by (Domain 10) are discounted cash flows wearing covenants.

Learning objectives. After this domain a candidate can: distinguish simple and compound interest and compute either; move any cash amount across time with $FV(x)$ and $PV(x)$ and read a discount-factor table; value level streams with annuity and perpetuity formulae; build and check a loan schedule (annuity, level-principal and bullet); convert between nominal, periodic and effective rates; keep nominal and real quantities consistent using the Fisher relation; escalate costs and revenues defensibly; state how currency and forward rates enter project cash flows; and apply the governed-AI rule to any machine-produced calculation of these kinds.

The master financing. One fictional project runs through this domain and returns in Domains 4, 6 and 10. **Kestrel Water SPC** is a special-purpose company developing a seawater desalination plant. Its senior lenders offer a **USD 42,000,000** loan repayable over **12 years at 6.0 %** annual interest; the offtaker will pay an **availability payment of USD 5,600,000 per year for 25 years**; Kestrel's board evaluates offers at a discount rate of **8.0 %**. All three numbers are used repeatedly below — by the end of the domain the reader can price every side of Kestrel's deal.

KNOWLEDGE AREA 3.1

Interest and value

Topics: 3.1.1 simple and compound interest · 3.1.2 present and future value · 3.1.3 discount factors.

3.1.1 Simple and compound interest

Definitions. Interest is the price of money over time. Under **simple interest** the charge accrues on the original principal only:

$$FV(x) = x \times (1 + r \times n) \quad \text{— simple interest}$$

Under **compound interest** each period's interest joins the principal and itself earns interest:

$$FV(x) = x \times (1 + r)^n \quad \text{— compound interest}$$

where x is the amount today (currency), r the interest rate per period (ratio) and n the number of periods (count). Project finance is a compound-interest world: loans, discounting, escalation and returns all compound. Simple interest survives only in narrow corners — short-duration instruments, some penalty-interest clauses, and certain Islamic-finance structures that avoid interest altogether and price time differently (Domain 9, KA 9.3).

The principle. Compounding is growth on growth. Its effect looks negligible over one or two periods and decisive over ten: the gap between the two formulae widens geometrically, which is why long-life infrastructure — concessions of 25 to 40 years — is acutely sensitive to the rate used.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example 3.1.1 — the same deposit, two rules.

1. **Setup.** USD 100,000 is placed for 3 years at 8.0 % per year. Compare simple and compound growth.
2. **Formula.** Simple: $FV(x) = x(1 + rn)$. Compound: $FV(x) = x(1 + r)^n$, with $x = 100,000$, $r = 0.08$, $n = 3$.
3. **Substitution.** Simple: $100,000 \times (1 + 0.08 \times 3) = 100,000 \times 1.24$. Compound: $100,000 \times 1.08^3 = 100,000 \times 1.259712$.
4. **Result.** Simple: **USD 124,000**. Compound: **USD 125,971** (125,971.20 at full precision).
5. **Interpretation.** Three years of compounding adds USD 1,971 over simple interest — under 2 %. Over a 25-year concession life the same 8 % compounds to $1.08^{25} \approx 6.85$ times the principal, while simple interest reaches only 3.0 times. The professional habit this example teaches: never extrapolate a short-horizon intuition to a long-horizon contract.

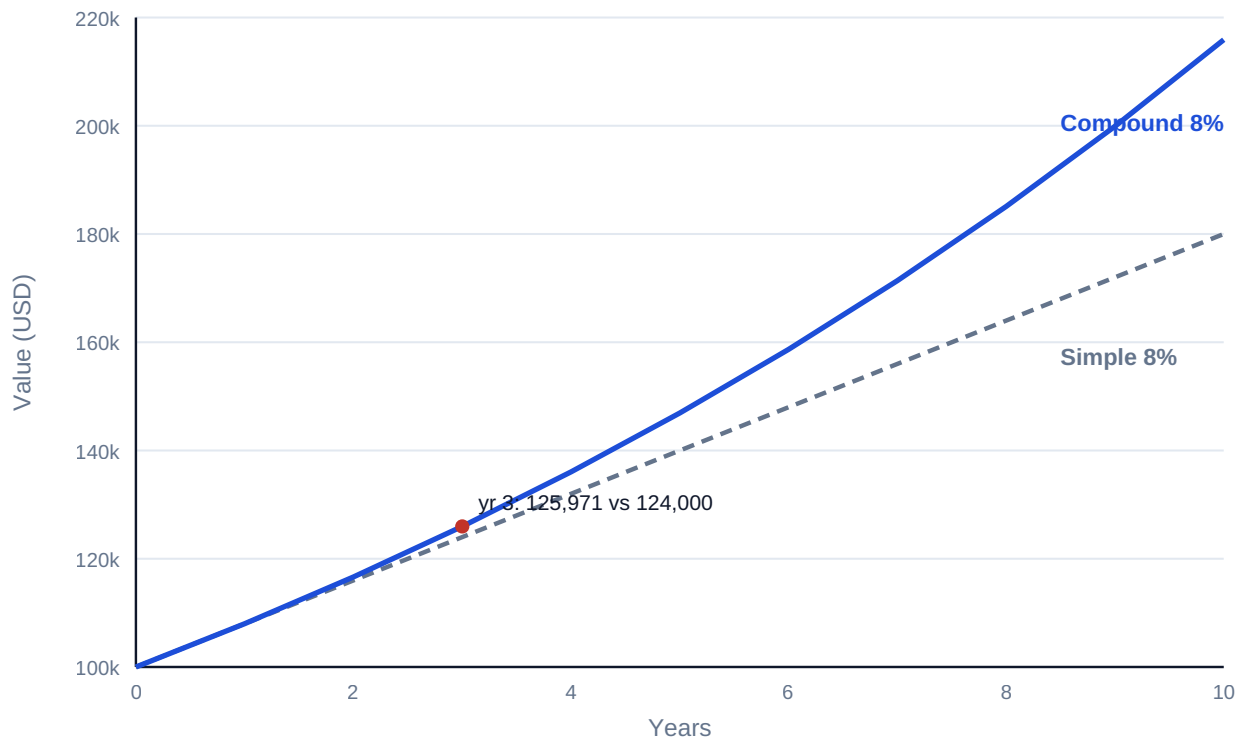


Fig 3.1.1 — Simple versus compound growth of USD 100,000 at 8 %

3.1.2 Present and future value

Definitions. Compounding runs both ways. **Future value** carries an amount forward; **present value** brings a future amount back:

$$FV(x) = x \times (1 + r)^n$$

$$PV(x) = x / (1 + r)^n$$

$PV(x)$ answers the only question a bid evaluation, a settlement offer or a buy-out negotiation really asks: what is that future money worth today, at the return I could otherwise earn? The rate r used in this role is called the **discount rate**; choosing it is a Domain 4 judgment (and, for a levered project, a Domain 9/10 conversation) — this KA takes it as given.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example 3.1.2 — pricing a deferred receipt.

1. **Setup.** Kestrel will receive a USD 500,000 connection rebate exactly 5 years from now. The board discounts at 7.0 % for this risk. What is the rebate worth today?
2. **Formula.** $PV(x) = x / (1 + r)^n$, with $x = 500,000$, $r = 0.07$, $n = 5$.
3. **Substitution.** $PV(x) = 500,000 / 1.07^5 = 500,000 / 1.402552$.
4. **Result.** **USD 356,493** (356,493.09 at full precision).
5. **Interpretation.** A five-year wait at 7 % costs the rebate just under 29 % of its face value. If a counterparty offered USD 380,000 cash today to extinguish the obligation, Kestrel should accept — and if offered USD 330,000, decline. $PV(x)$ turns "later" into a number that can be compared, which is the whole trade of this profession.

Common pitfall. Discounting with simple interest — $500,000 / (1 + 0.07 \times 5) = 370,370$ — overstates the value by USD 13,877 here. The error grows with horizon and rate; audit any model whose discount factors were "simplified".

3.1.3 Discount factors

Definition. The **discount factor** for period t is the present value of one currency unit received at t :

$$DF(t) = 1 / (1 + r)^t \quad \text{so that} \quad PV(x \text{ at } t) = x \times DF(t)$$

Discount factors are how models industrialise discounting: compute the factor row once, multiply every cash-flow row by it (Domain 6, KA 6.1). They also make review fast — an experienced reviewer reads a factor table the way a scheduler reads float.

At $r = 10\%$:

t (years)	1	2	3	4	5
$DF(t)$	0.9091	0.8264	0.7513	0.6830	0.6209

Two sanity rules a reviewer applies on sight: factors must **decline monotonically**, and each factor must equal the previous factor divided by $(1 + r)$. A factor table that violates either has a hard-coded cell or a broken formula — a Domain 6 model-check classic (KA 6.4).

Rounding discipline. Factors are displayed to four decimals but **calculations use full precision**. Multiplying a USD 900,000,000 programme cash flow by a four-decimal factor can move results by tens of thousands; the display is for the reader, never for the arithmetic (see the registry's decimal-arithmetic rule).

AI in this KA

Spreadsheet copilots will happily draft TVM formulae, and large-language-model assistants will "explain" a discount factor with perfect fluency and an inverted exponent. The governed position (the PCI principle: **AI proposes; the professional verifies, decides and remains accountable**) is mechanical here because verification is cheap: recompute one factor by hand, check monotonicity, check $DF(1) \times (1+r) = 1$. An AI-drafted factor row that no human recomputed is not a calculation; it is a claim.

■ KEY TERMS — KA 3.1

Term	Meaning
Simple interest	Interest accruing on original principal only: $FV(x) = x(1 + rn)$.
Compound interest	Interest accruing on principal and accumulated interest: $FV(x) = x(1 + r)^n$.
Present value $PV(x)$	Today's worth of a future amount at discount rate r .
Future value $FV(x)$	The compounded worth of an amount at a future date.
Discount rate	The rate r used to move value across time; the required return for the risk.
Discount factor $DF(t)$	$1/(1+r)^t$; the PV of one unit received at t .

■ SAMPLE MCQS — KA 3.1

MCQ 3.1-A [3.1.2 · Application] A payment of USD 500,000 is due in 5 years; the discount rate is 7 %. Its present value is closest to: - A. USD 370,370 - B. USD 356,493 - C. USD 381,448 - D. USD 701,276

Rationale: $500,000 / 1.07^5 = 356,493$. A discounts with simple interest ($1 + 0.35$); C uses four years instead of five; D compounds forward instead of discounting back.

MCQ 3.1-B [3.1.3 · Application] At a 10 % discount rate, the discount factor for year 3 is: - A. 0.7000 - B. 0.8264 - C. 0.7513 - D. 0.6830

Rationale: $1/1.10^3 = 0.7513$. A subtracts 10 % three times (simple); B is the year-2 factor; D is the year-4 factor — the two most common off-by-one-period errors.

MCQ 3.1-C [3.1.1 · Analysis] A lender quotes 25-year money and a borrower's analyst tests affordability using simple interest "as a conservative shortcut". The analyst's error is that: - A. simple interest overstates the debt cost, so the test is merely too strict - B. compound growth exceeds simple growth over long horizons, so the shortcut materially understates the true accumulation - C. the two methods converge over long horizons, so the shortcut is harmless - D. simple interest cannot be computed for horizons beyond ten years

Rationale: Compounding produces growth on growth: at 8 % over 25 years the compound multiple is ≈ 6.85 versus 3.0 simple — the shortcut is anti-conservative, the opposite of the analyst's claim (so A is wrong); the methods diverge rather than converge (C); D is arithmetic nonsense.

■ SELF-CHECK — KA 3.1

1. Why must discount factors decline monotonically? — Because $(1+r)^t$ grows with t for any positive r ; a rising factor implies a negative rate or a broken formula.
2. Your model shows $DF(4) = 0.6830$ and $DF(5) = 0.6209$ at 10 %. One cell check confirms both. Which? — $0.6830 / 1.10 = 0.6209$: each factor is the prior factor divided by $(1+r)$.
3. A colleague says "8 % for three years is 24 %". — Only under simple interest; compounded it is $1.08^3 - 1 = 25.97$ %, and the gap widens every further year.

KNOWLEDGE AREA 3.2

Annuities and loan schedules

Topics: 3.2.1 annuities and perpetuities · 3.2.2 loan schedules · 3.2.3 compounding frequency and effective rates.

3.2.1 Annuities and perpetuities

Definitions. An **annuity** is a level stream — the same amount each period for n periods. Project finance is built from annuities and near-annuities: availability payments, capacity charges, lease rentals, O&M fees, debt service. The present value of an ordinary annuity (payments at period-ends) of amount A :

$$PV(\text{annuity}) = A \times AF(r, n) \quad \text{where} \quad AF(r, n) = (1 - (1 + r)^{-n}) / r$$

$AF(r, n)$ is the **annuity factor** — the sum of the discount factors $DF(1) \dots DF(n)$. A **perpetuity** is the limiting case as $n \rightarrow \infty$:

$$PV(\text{perpetuity}) = A / r$$

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example 3.2.1 — valuing Kestrel's availability stream.

1. **Setup.** Kestrel's offtaker will pay USD 3,000,000 per year for 20 years under an early tariff proposal, paid annually in arrears. The board discounts at 9.0 %. Value the stream.
2. **Formula.** $PV = A \times AF(r, n)$, $AF(r, n) = (1 - (1+r)^{-n})/r$, with $A = 3,000,000$, $r = 0.09$, $n = 20$.
3. **Substitution.** $AF(0.09, 20) = (1 - 1.09^{-20})/0.09 = 9.128546$; $PV = 3,000,000 \times 9.128546$.
4. **Result.** **USD 27,385,637** (using the full-precision factor).
5. **Interpretation.** Twenty years of payments are worth barely nine years' worth of face value — discounting at 9 % has priced away more than half the nominal USD 60,000,000 total. Sensitivity: at a 10 % rate the factor falls to 8.513564 and the value to USD 25,540,691 — a 6.7 % value loss for one point of rate, the shape of sensitivity every concession bidder lives with (Domain 7, KA 7.4).

Common pitfall — the rounded factor. Using a four-decimal factor (9.1285) gives USD 27,385,500 — USD 137 adrift here, but scale the stream by 100× and the drift is five figures. Factors are display; arithmetic is full precision (KA 3.1.3).

Timing variants. An **annuity-due** (payments in advance, common in leases and some availability regimes) is worth $(1 + r)$ times the ordinary annuity. Misreading the payment convention in a concession agreement misprices the whole stream by one period's discounting — check the contract, not the habit (Domain 12, KA 12.2).

3.2.2 Loan schedules

The three canonical shapes. A loan of principal P over n periods at rate r can be scheduled three ways, and a project finance leader must read all three on sight:

Shape	Rule	Debt-service profile	Where seen
Annuity (equal instalment)	Payment $A = P \times r / (1 - (1+r)^{-n})$ each period	Level total; interest share falls, principal share rises	Most project term loans; mortgages
Level principal	Principal P/n each period + interest on balance	Front-loaded total, declining	Some ECA and development-bank facilities (Domain 9)
Bullet	Interest only; principal entire at maturity	Low until the final balloon	Bonds; mini-perm structures; refinancing plays (Domain 15)

WORKED EXAMPLE**Worked example 3.2.2 — Kestrel's senior loan.**

1. **Setup.** USD 42,000,000, 12 annual instalments, 6.0 % — annuity shape. Find the instalment and build the first three schedule rows.
2. **Formula.** $A = P \times r / (1 - (1+r)^{-n})$, with $P = 42,000,000$, $r = 0.06$, $n = 12$. Each row: interest = opening balance $\times r$; principal = $A - \text{interest}$; closing = opening — principal.
3. **Substitution.** $A = 42,000,000 \times 0.06 / (1 - 1.06^{-12}) = 42,000,000 / 8.383844$.
4. **Result.** $A = \text{USD } 5,009,635$ per year (5,009,635.23). Schedule:

Year	Opening balance	Interest (6 %)	Principal	Closing balance
1	42,000,000	2,520,000	2,489,635	39,510,365
2	39,510,365	2,370,622	2,639,013	36,871,351
3	36,871,351	2,212,281	2,797,354	34,073,997

1. **Interpretation.** The instalment never changes; its composition does — year 1 is 50 % interest, and by the final year almost all principal. Two checks a reviewer runs instantly: the closing balance after year 12 must be exactly zero (a residual means a formula error), and total principal across all rows must equal P . This schedule is the direct input to Kestrel's debt service line — and therefore to its DSCR — in Domains 6 and 10.

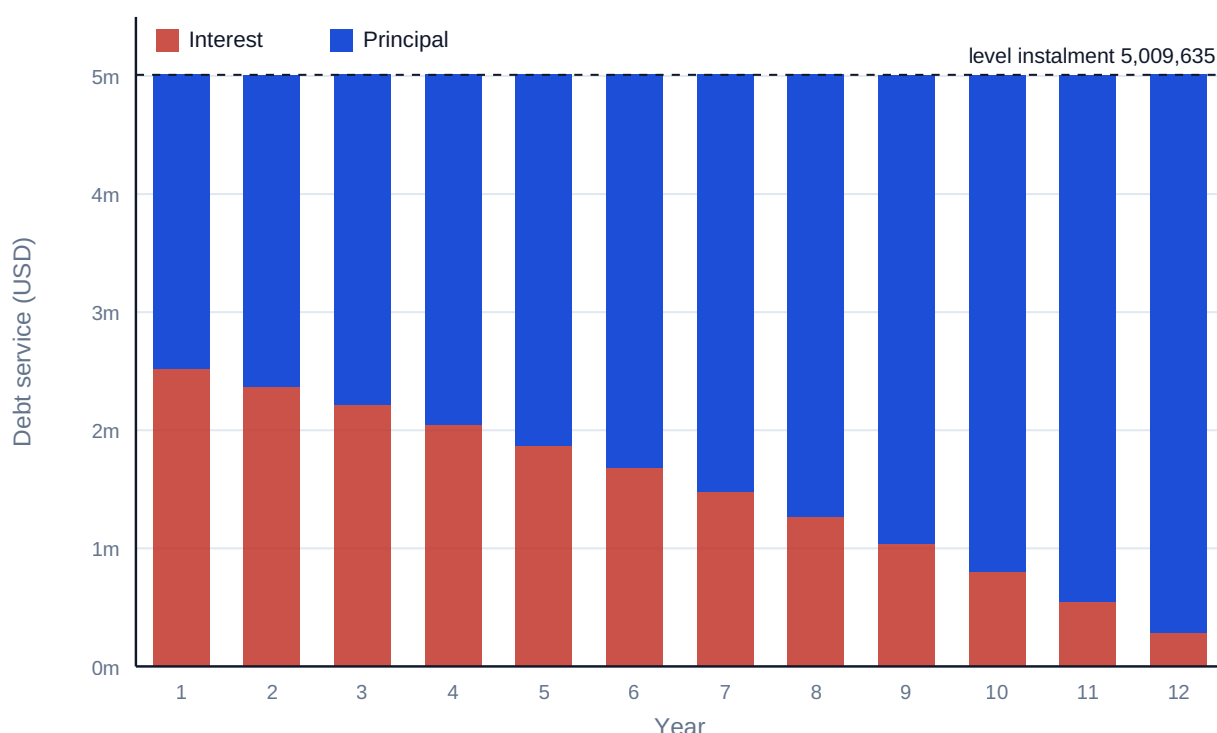


Fig 3.2.1 — Anatomy of an annuity loan: Kestrel's USD 42,000,000, 12 years at 6 %

Common pitfall — the bullet that looks cheap. A bullet's early debt service is a fraction of an annuity's, and a cash-strapped sponsor will feel the temptation. The full price appears at maturity as

refinancing risk — the balloon must be refinanced at whatever the market then charges (Domain 15, KA 15.3). Case study B prices this trade.

3.2.3 Compounding frequency and effective rates

Definitions. A quoted **nominal annual rate** i_{nom} compounded m times per year applies i_{nom}/m per period. The **effective annual rate (EAR)** is the once-a-year rate that produces the same growth:

$$\text{EAR} = (1 + i_{\text{nom}} / m)^m - 1$$

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example 3.2.3 — the same 6 %, four ways.

1. **Setup.** A facility is quoted at "6 % nominal". Find the effective annual rate if compounding is annual, semi-annual, quarterly and monthly.
2. **Formula.** $\text{EAR} = (1 + 0.06/m)^m - 1$ for $m = 1, 2, 4, 12$.
3. **Substitution.** $m=4$: $(1 + 0.015)^4 - 1 = 1.061364 - 1$.
4. **Result.** Annual **6.000 %** · semi-annual **6.090 %** · quarterly **6.136 %** · monthly **6.168 %**.
5. **Interpretation.** "Six per cent" is not one price; it is four prices in this example alone, and the differences compound over a 12-year loan. Term sheets are compared on effective rates, never on quoted nominals — and loan models must use the **periodic** rate i_{nom}/m with $n \times m$ periods, not the EAR with n years, or debt service will be misstated (Domain 6, KA 6.3).

AI in this KA

Amortisation is where AI-assisted modelling earns its keep — and where it must be caged. Generating a 360-row monthly schedule is exactly the mechanical work a copilot does well; whether the schedule uses the periodic rate correctly, honours the day-count convention in the actual facility agreement, and zeroes the final balance is exactly what it gets wrong silently. The governed workflow (Domain 6, KA 6.4; Domain 16): AI drafts the schedule; the professional runs the three deterministic checks (final balance zero; Σ principal = P ; payment recomputed independently) before any output leaves the model.

■ KEY TERMS — KA 3.2

Term	Meaning
Annuity / annuity-due	Level periodic stream, in arrears / in advance.
Annuity factor $AF(r, n)$	$(1 - (1+r)^{-n})/r$; PV of 1 per period for n periods.
Perpetuity	Level stream forever; $PV = A/r$.
Annuity, level-principal, bullet	The three canonical loan shapes.
Balloon / refinancing risk	The bullet's maturity principal and the risk of the rate then prevailing.
Nominal rate / EAR	Quoted annual rate with compounding frequency / its once-a-year equivalent.

■ SAMPLE MCQS — KA 3.2

MCQ 3.2-A [3.2.2 · Application] A USD 42,000,000 loan is repaid by 12 equal annual instalments at 6 %. The instalment is closest to: - A. USD 3,500,000 - B. USD 2,520,000 - C. USD 5,009,635 - D. USD 5,706,454

Rationale: $42,000,000 \times 0.06 / (1 - 1.06^{-12}) = 5,009,635$. A divides principal by 12 and ignores interest; B is interest-only on the full balance; D uses a 10-year annuity factor — the wrong-tenor error.

MCQ 3.2-B [3.2.3 · Application] A 6 % nominal rate compounded quarterly has an effective annual rate of: - A. 6.00 % - B. 6.09 % - C. 6.14 % - D. 6.17 %

Rationale: $(1 + 0.015)^4 - 1 = 6.136 \% \approx 6.14 \%$. A is the nominal itself; B is semi-annual compounding; D is monthly — each a frequency misread.

MCQ 3.2-C [3.2.1 · Analysis] Two otherwise identical concession bids value the same 20-year availability stream. Bid X used the full-precision annuity factor; Bid Y rounded the factor to four decimals. The most defensible statement is: - A. the bids differ by an amount that grows with the size of the stream, and only X's practice passes model audit - B. rounding the factor is conservative, so Y understates value and is safer - C. the difference is always immaterial because four decimals is industry standard - D. Y's approach is wrong only if the discount rate exceeds 10 %

Rationale: Factor rounding error scales linearly with the cash flows and has no consistent conservative direction (B, D wrong); materiality depends on scale, not convention (C wrong); model audit standards require full-precision arithmetic with display-only rounding.

■ SELF-CHECK — KA 3.2

1. What two instant checks validate any amortising schedule? — Final closing balance exactly zero; total principal equals the original loan.
2. Why is an annuity-due worth $(1+r) \times$ the ordinary annuity? — Every payment arrives one period earlier, so each escapes one period of discounting.
3. A term sheet quotes "5.9 % monthly"; another "6.0 % annual". Which is dearer? — The first: $(1 + 0.059/12)^{12} - 1 = 6.06 \%$ effective, above 6.00 %.

KNOWLEDGE AREA 3.3

Real-world adjustments: inflation, escalation and currency

Topics: 3.3.1 nominal and real rates · 3.3.2 inflation and escalation · 3.3.3 currency effects.

3.3.1 Nominal and real rates — the Fisher relation

Definitions. A **nominal** rate i_{nom} is quoted in money terms; a **real** rate i_{real} is measured in purchasing power, after inflation π . They are linked by the **Fisher relation**:

$$(1 + i_{\text{nom}}) = (1 + i_{\text{real}}) \times (1 + \pi) \quad \text{so} \quad i_{\text{real}} = (1 + i_{\text{nom}}) / (1 + \pi) - 1$$

The subtraction shortcut $i_{\text{real}} \approx i_{\text{nom}} - \pi$ is a first-order approximation only — usable for intuition, never for models.

WORKED EXAMPLE**Worked example 3.3.1 — the real cost of Kestrel's equity hurdle.**

1. **Setup.** Kestrel's shareholders require a 9.0 % nominal return; inflation is expected at 3.0 %. What real return are they actually demanding?
2. **Formula.** $i_{\text{real}} = (1 + i_{\text{nom}})/(1 + \pi) - 1$, with $i_{\text{nom}} = 0.09$, $\pi = 0.03$.
3. **Substitution.** $i_{\text{real}} = 1.09 / 1.03 - 1 = 1.058252 - 1$.
4. **Result.** **5.83 %** real (5.8252 % at full precision). The subtraction shortcut says 6.00 % — 17 basis points high.
5. **Interpretation.** Seventeen basis points sounds academic until it is applied to a 25-year stream: mispricing the hurdle by that much moves a large concession's value by roughly one and a half years' worth of payments. Models must live entirely in one world — nominal cash flows with nominal rates, or real with real. **Mixing them is the single most common TVM defect found in model audits** (Domain 6, KA 6.4; Domain 13, KA 13.2).

3.3.2 Inflation and escalation

Definitions. **Inflation** is the general price level's drift; **escalation** is the contractual or forecast growth of a specific price — a tariff indexed to CPI, labour rates under a collective agreement, steel under a commodity formula. An amount x escalating at rate e for n periods becomes $x \times (1 + e)^n$. Escalation compounds, exactly like interest — and like interest, it is routinely underestimated over long horizons.

WORKED EXAMPLE**Worked example 3.3.2 — an O&M contract's third-year price.**

1. **Setup.** Kestrel's O&M contract prices year-0 services at USD 10,000,000, escalating 4.0 % annually. What is the year-3 price?
2. **Formula.** $x_n = x_0 \times (1 + e)^n$, with $x_0 = 10,000,000$, $e = 0.04$, $n = 3$.
3. **Substitution.** $10,000,000 \times 1.04^3 = 10,000,000 \times 1.124864$.
4. **Result.** **USD 11,248,640.**
5. **Interpretation.** Simple-escalation thinking says "+12 %" (USD 11,200,000); compounding adds USD 48,640 by year 3 and the gap widens every year after. In a 25-year operating model the compound-vs-simple escalation choice changes lifecycle cost by whole percentage points — Domain 8 (KA 8.2) builds the full escalated cash-flow machinery on this rule.

Indexation discipline. Real contracts escalate on published indices with definitions, lags, caps and floors (Domain 7, KA 7.3; Domain 12). A model's escalation assumptions must cite the contractual index and its mechanics, not a bare percentage — the toolkit's escalation register (3.T.3) exists for exactly this.

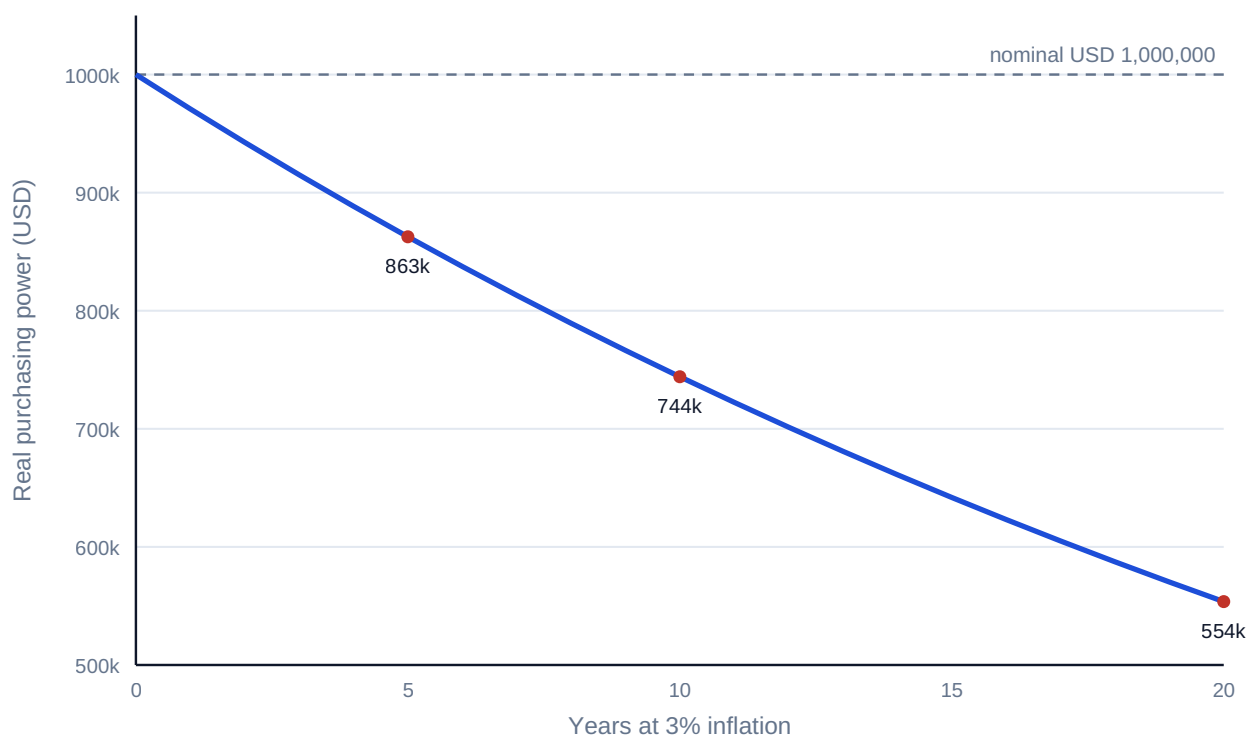


Fig 3.3.1 — What 3 % inflation does to USD 1,000,000 of purchasing power

3.3.3 Currency effects

The problem. Project cash flows often arrive in one currency while debt service, equipment or returns are owed in another. Two rates matter: the **spot rate** now, and the **forward rate** at which future exchange can be contracted. Forwards are priced off interest differentials (covered interest parity, stated here in its textbook form):

$$F \approx S \times (1 + i_{\text{quote}}) / (1 + i_{\text{base}})$$

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example 3.3.3 — a one-year SAR/USD forward.

- Setup.** Spot USD 1 = SAR 3.7500 (the indicative peg rate used throughout this book). One-year money costs 5.0 % in USD and 5.5 % in SAR. Estimate the one-year forward.
- Formula.** $F = S \times (1 + i_{\text{SAR}}) / (1 + i_{\text{USD}})$, with $S = 3.7500$.
- Substitution.** $F = 3.7500 \times 1.055 / 1.05$.
- Result.** SAR 3.7679 per USD.
- Interpretation.** The forward is not a forecast; it is arithmetic — the rate at which borrowing in one currency and lending in the other breaks even. A project that leaves a currency mismatch unhedged is not "expecting the spot to hold"; it is running an open position whose size Domain 11 (KA 11.3) teaches you to measure and whose contractual mitigations Domain 12 allocates. **Assumption honesty:** actual pegs, spreads and convertibility restrictions are jurisdiction- and time-specific; every currency figure in this book is illustrative.

AI in this domain — the systematic view

TVM is deterministic, which makes it the safest place in finance to use machine assistance and the most dangerous place to trust it unchecked: a wrong exponent produces a plausible number, not an absurd one. The domain's governed workflow, applied wherever Domains 4-16 discount anything:

1. **AI proposes** — drafts the factor table, schedule or escalated series.
2. **Deterministic checks** — monotone factors; $DF(1)(1+r) = 1$; schedule zeroes; Σ principal = P ; one hand-recomputed cell per block.
3. **Assumption register** — rate, basis (nominal/real), compounding frequency, index, and currency of every stream written down (toolkit 3.T.1).
4. **The professional decides and remains accountable** — no AI-produced number reaches a board paper, bid or lender report without a named human owner (Domain 16, KA 16.4).

■ KEY TERMS — KA 3.3

Term	Meaning
Nominal / real rate	Money-terms rate / purchasing-power rate; linked by Fisher.
Fisher relation	$(1+i_{\text{nom}}) = (1+i_{\text{real}})(1+\pi)$.
Inflation π / escalation e	General price drift / specific contractual price growth.
Indexation	Contractual escalation by a published index, with lags, caps, floors.
Spot / forward rate	Exchange rate now / contracted for a future date.
Covered interest parity	Forward $\approx$ spot $\times$ interest-ratio; the no-arbitrage forward.

■ SAMPLE MCQS — KA 3.3

MCQ 3.3-A [3.3.1 · Application] Nominal return 9 %, inflation 3 %. The real return is closest to: - A. 6.00 % - B. 5.83 % - C. 12.27 % - D. 3.00 %

Rationale: $1.09/1.03 - 1 = 5.83$ %. A is the subtraction approximation; C multiplies $1.09 \times 1.03 - 1$ (compounding inflation on instead of off); D confuses the inflation rate itself with the real return.

MCQ 3.3-B [3.3.2 · Application] A USD 10,000,000 cost escalating at 4 % per year is, in year 3: - A. USD 11,200,000 - B. USD 10,400,000 - C. USD 12,486,400 - D. USD 11,248,640

Rationale: $10,000,000 \times 1.04^3 = 11,248,640$. A escalates simply (3×4 %); B stops at one year; C applies four periods' escalation with a decimal slip.

MCQ 3.3-C [3.3.1 · Analysis] A model discounts real (uninflated) cash flows at the sponsor's nominal 9 % hurdle. The result: - A. overstates value, because inflation is counted twice - B. understates value, because inflation is removed from the flows but still charged in the rate - C. is correct if inflation is below 5 % - D. is correct because discount rates are always nominal

Rationale: Real flows with a nominal rate deduct inflation twice — once from the flows, once inside the rate — so value is systematically understated. The consistency rule admits no threshold (C) and no default (D); A reverses the direction of the error.

■ SELF-CHECK — KA 3.3

1. State the consistency rule. — Nominal flows with nominal rates, real flows with real rates; never mixed in one calculation.

2. Why does a 25-year concession make the Fisher shortcut dangerous? — The 17 bp error (at 9 %/3 %) compounds across every one of 25 discount factors.
 3. Is a forward rate a forecast? — No: it is the no-arbitrage consequence of today's spot and the two interest rates.
-

— Advanced topics — Domain 3

3.A.1 Continuous compounding

As compounding frequency $m \rightarrow \infty$, $(1 + r/m)^{mn} \rightarrow e^{rn}$. USD 100,000 at 8 % for 3 years compounds continuously to $100,000 \times e^{0.24} = \text{USD } 127,125$ — against 125,971 annually. In project work continuous compounding appears mainly in derivative pricing and some academic appraisal literature; its practical value here is as a bound: no compounding frequency can push growth beyond e^{rn} .

3.A.2 Irregular timing and period conventions

Real cash flows do not arrive on anniversary dates. Three conventions bridge the gap: **exact-date discounting** (each flow discounted by its actual day count — the XNPV approach, standard in transaction models); the **mid-period convention** (flows treated as arriving mid-period, appropriate for continuous operations revenue); and **period-end** (conservative for receipts, default in lender base cases). The convention is an assumption — it belongs in the assumption register, it changes results by up to half a period's discounting, and model audits (Domain 13, KA 13.2) check that one convention is applied everywhere.

3.A.3 Term structures — when one rate is not enough

A single flat r assumes money has the same price at every horizon. Markets disagree: rates form a **term structure**, and precise valuation discounts each period's flow at that period's rate (equivalently, its own $DF(t)$ from a curve). Project models typically justify a flat rate as a deliberate simplification of a curve — acceptable when documented and stress-tested (Domain 6, KA 6.4), a silent error when inherited unexamined from a template.

3.A.4 The reviewer's TVM eye

Experienced reviewers do not recompute everything; they run invariants. The domain's collected set: factors decline; $DF(1)(1+r) = 1$; annuity factor $\times r \rightarrow 1 - DF(n)$; schedules zero out; $\Sigma \text{ principal} = P$; effective $\geq$ nominal, with equality only at annual compounding; real $<$ nominal whenever $\pi > 0$; forward off-spot in the direction of the interest differential. Any violated invariant is a defect somewhere — find it before anyone downstream builds on it.

— Case study — Domain 3: choosing between an upfront grant and an availability stream (water / PPP)

Situation. Kestrel Water SPC's grantor offers two support packages for the desalination concession, and the board must choose one at financial close:

- **Package U:** a single upfront capital grant of **USD 58,000,000** at completion.
- **Package S:** an availability supplement of **USD 5,600,000 per year for 25 years**, paid annually in arrears from completion.

Kestrel evaluates support at its 8.0 % project discount rate. The grantor's advisers privately evaluate at 10 %.

Analysis. The stream's value to Kestrel: $AF(0.08, 25) = (1 - 1.08^{-25})/0.08 = 10.674776$; $PV = 5,600,000 \times 10.674776 = \text{USD } 59,778,747$ — worth **USD 1,778,747 more** than the upfront grant. To the grantor's advisers at 10 %: $AF(0.10, 25) = 9.077040$; $PV = 5,600,000 \times 9.077040 = \text{USD } 50,831,424$ — worth **USD 7,168,576 less** than the grant they would otherwise pay today.

The decision. Both sides prefer a different package from the same facts — a discount-rate wedge, not a disagreement about arithmetic. Kestrel takes the stream (worth more at 8 %); the grantor is glad to give it (cheaper at 10 %); the deal closes with both counterparties better off by their own measure. The board minute records the rate, the convention (annual, in arrears) and the sensitivity: the stream's advantage to Kestrel disappears if its discount rate rises past ≈ 8.35 % — the **breakeven rate** at which $AF \times 5,600,000 = 58,000,000$, i.e. $AF = 10.357$.

What the domain teaches here. Valuation is always at a rate, for a party; streams and lumps are only comparable through $PV(x)$; and the negotiation surface between two parties' rates is where structuring value lives (Domain 7 revisits this as tariff design; Domain 9 as the grant-versus-support decision).

— Case study B — Domain 3: the bullet that had to be refinanced (energy / refinancing)

Situation. A 30 MW peaking-plant SPV borrowed **USD 30,000,000** for 7 years. The sponsor chose a **bullet** (interest-only at 7.5 %, principal at maturity) over the lenders' preferred **annuity** shape, to keep early cash for distributions.

The two prices. Annuity instalment: $A = 30,000,000 \times 0.075/(1 - 1.075^{-7}) = \text{USD } 5,664,009$ per year; total paid 39,648,066, of which interest **USD 9,648,066**. Bullet: interest $30,000,000 \times 0.075 = 2,250,000$ per year — total interest **USD 15,750,000**, plus the full USD 30,000,000 due in year 7. The bullet pays **USD 6,101,934 more interest** for the privilege of deferral — and retains the entire principal as **refinancing risk**.

What happened. At year 7 the credit market had repriced: the refinancing cleared at 9.8 %, and the new 7-year annuity instalment on the rolled principal became $30,000,000 \times 0.098/(1 - 1.098^{-7}) = 6,121,646$ — against 5,664,009 had the original annuity simply been running to zero. Distributions locked up under the new facility's covenants for two years (Domain 10, KA 10.4).

What the domain teaches here. A schedule shape is a risk allocation, not a formatting choice: the annuity retires rate risk continuously; the bullet stores it at maturity, priced at a rate nobody today knows. Deferral has a computable minimum cost (the interest differential) and an uncomputable tail (the refinancing market) — leadership means pricing the first honestly and sizing the second deliberately (Domain 15, KA 15.3).

— Executive perspective — Domain 3

What a project finance director cannot delegate in this domain:

- **The rate.** Analysts compute with a discount rate; directors own it. Whoever sets r sets the answer — the choice is a governance act (Domain 4 gives it method; Domain 3 makes its power visible).
- **The world.** Nominal or real, once, for the whole model — and the director asks which, out loud, at the first model review.
- **The conventions.** In-arrears vs in-advance, compounding frequency, day counts, escalation indices: each is small, each moves millions at scale, and together they are why the assumption register (3.T.1) is a board-visible artefact, not analyst hygiene.
- **The verification culture.** The invariants of 3.A.4 cost minutes; unverified TVM in a signed bid costs careers. The director's question is never "who computed this?" but "who recomputed this?" — and, where AI drafted it, the answer must name a human.

— Calculation exercises — Domain 3

Exercise 3.1 A land payment of USD 850,000 falls due in 8 years; the applicable discount rate is 11 %. Value it today. Solution. $PV = 850,000 / 1.11^8 = 850,000 / 2.304538 = \text{USD } 368,838$ (368,837.52). Common error: using $n = 7$ gives 409,410 — an off-by-one from counting "in 8 years" as 7 compounding periods.

Exercise 3.2 A USD 2,500,000 equipment loan is repaid monthly over 20 years at a 5.0 % nominal annual rate compounded monthly. Find the monthly payment. Solution. Periodic rate $0.05/12 = 0.004167$; $n = 240$; $A = 2,500,000 \times 0.004167 / (1 - 1.004167^{-240}) = \text{USD } 16,499$ per month (16,498.89). Common error: using the EAR (5.116 %) with 20 annual periods misstates debt service materially.

Exercise 3.3 Convert a 12 % nominal rate compounded monthly to its effective annual rate. Solution. $(1 + 0.01)^{12} - 1 = 1.126825 - 1 = 12.68 \%$. Common error: reporting 12 % — the nominal — as "the rate" in a comparison against an annually-compounded 12.5 % offer, which is in fact cheaper.

Exercise 3.4 A transmission wayleave pays USD 1,200,000 per year indefinitely; the discount rate is 8.5 %. Value the perpetuity. Solution. $PV = 1,200,000 / 0.085 = \text{USD } 14,117,647$. Common error: applying a long annuity factor (say 30 years, $AF = 10.694$) "as approximately forever" understates value by $\approx 9 \%$.

Exercise 3.5 A market forecast promises a 12 % nominal return with 5 % inflation. State the real return, exactly and by the shortcut, and the shortcut's error. Solution. Exact: $1.12/1.05 - 1 = 6.67 \%$ (6.6667 %). Shortcut: $12 - 5 = 7.00 \%$. The shortcut overstates the real return by **33 basis points** — material over any long horizon.

— Practitioner's toolkit — Domain 3

Adoption-ready artefacts; adapt headings to your organisation, then keep them stable.

Toolkit 3.T.1 — TVM assumption register (one row per modelled stream)

Field	Discipline it enforces
Stream name & source document	Every number traces to a contract or estimate
Currency	Mismatches surface (KA 3.3.3)
Nominal or real	The consistency rule (3.3.1), stated not assumed
Rate & its owner	The director owns r (Executive perspective)
Compounding frequency & day count	Effective-rate honesty (3.2.3)
Timing convention (arrears/advance/mid-period)	Half-period errors caught (3.A.2)
Escalation index, lag, cap/floor	Contractual, not invented (3.3.2)

Toolkit 3.T.2 — Schedule QA checklist

- [] Payment recomputed independently of the model (different implementer or method).
- [] Final balance exactly zero; Σ principal = original loan.
- [] Periodic rate = nominal / frequency; period count = years $\times$ frequency.
- [] Discount factors monotone; $DF(1) \times (1 + r) = 1$.
- [] Display rounding only — full precision beneath every printed figure.
- [] AI-drafted content marked, and its human verifier named (Domain 16, KA 16.4).

Toolkit 3.T.3 — Escalation register

For each escalating line: base amount and base date · index (publisher, series, definition) · lag · formula (full/partial indexation, weightings) · cap/floor · compounding basis · the clause reference in the contract. A model whose escalation register is complete can survive a Domain 13 model audit; one whose escalation is "4 % because last year" cannot.

— Exam preparation — Domain 3

The calculation traps. Off-by-one periods ("in year 5" vs "after 5 years") · simple-for- compound substitution · rounded discount factors in the arithmetic · annuity-due priced as ordinary · EAR used as the periodic rate · nominal/real mixing · escalation applied simply · tenor mismatch in annuity factors (the 3.2-A distractor D) · treating a forward as a forecast.

Reflection questions. 1. Your CFO asks for "the value of the concession". What three questions must you answer before any number is defensible? (At what rate; in which world — nominal or real; under which timing conventions.) 2. A lender and a sponsor disagree about the value of the same payment stream. Under what conditions are both right — and where does that create negotiating room? (Case study A.) 3. Which invariant checks would have caught the last TVM error you saw in the wild — and why didn't they run? (3.A.4; toolkit 3.T.2.)

— Domain 3 summary

Money's value is a function of time, and this domain built the complete conversion machinery: compounding and discounting ($FV(x)$, $PV(x)$, $DF(t)$); the annuity family that prices every level stream from availability payments to debt service ($AF(r, n)$, perpetuities, the three loan shapes and their risk meanings); frequency and effective-rate honesty; and the three real-world adjustments — Fisher-consistent inflation treatment, contract-grade escalation, and no-arbitrage currency forwards. Its discipline is as important as its formulae: one world per model, full precision beneath displayed rounding, conventions in the assumption register, invariants run on every schedule, and machine-drafted arithmetic verified by a named human before anyone relies on it. Every discounted number in the thirteen domains that follow stands on this one.

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